

Qiskit Fall Fest 2026 at UConn Storrs

Event Code of Conduct | October 15-17, 2026 | University of Connecticut, Storrs

1. Purpose, Commitment, and Governing Framework

Qiskit Fall Fest 2026 at UConn (the “Event”) is intended to provide a rigorous, collaborative, accessible, and professionally respectful environment for learning, technical exchange, networking, and hackathon participation. This Event Code of Conduct (the “Code”) establishes minimum standards of behavior for all persons participating in or supporting the Event and is designed to supplement, not replace, applicable law, University of Connecticut (“UConn” or the “University”) policies, the official Qiskit Code of Conduct, IBM policies applicable to IBM personnel or business partners, and any separately published Event rules.

The official Qiskit Code of Conduct applies to Qiskit events and online and offline Qiskit community spaces, and emphasizes respect and dignity, inclusive participation, professional behavior, privacy, and community responsibility. This Code incorporates those principles and adds event-specific provisions appropriate to a University-hosted hybrid program and in-person hackathon.

1.1 Order of Authority

Nothing in this Code shall be interpreted to waive, narrow, supersede, or privately modify obligations imposed by law or by a policy of an entity having jurisdiction. If a conflict arises, the Event Organizers will refer the matter to the appropriate UConn or IBM/Qiskit authority. UConn policies remain controlling as to University property, University programs, University personnel, and persons otherwise subject to University jurisdiction; IBM and Qiskit policies remain controlling as to IBM personnel, Qiskit community spaces, and other matters within IBM/Qiskit authority.

1.2 Participation as Acceptance

Registration for, attendance at, contribution to, or continued participation in the Event constitutes agreement to comply with this Code and with reasonable directions issued by Event Organizers concerning safety, access, scheduling, moderation, venue operations, and conduct. A participant who does not agree to these conditions should not participate in the Event.

1.3 Nature of this Document

This Code is an event-conduct instrument. It is not a substitute for a privacy notice, intellectual-property agreement, photo or media release, medical consent, liability waiver, employment policy, student disciplinary code, or legal advice. Any such terms, if required, should be presented separately and reviewed through the appropriate institutional process.

1.4 Core Standard

All participants shall conduct themselves in a manner consistent with a professional academic and technical environment: respectful of persons, protective of safety and privacy, honest in scholarship and competition, responsible in the use of technology, and responsive to lawful and reasonable Event directions. Conduct may violate this Code even when it does not independently satisfy the legal definition of unlawful harassment, discrimination, or another civil or criminal offense.

2. Scope, Persons Covered, and Defined Terms

2.1 Persons Covered

This Code applies to attendees, students, faculty, staff, speakers, mentors, judges, volunteers, organizers, sponsors, exhibitors, contractors, vendors, guests, online contributors, IBM employees, and any other person participating in or acting in connection with the Event (collectively, “Participants”). A person’s professional title, institutional affiliation, seniority, sponsorship status, or invited-speaker status does not exempt that person from this Code.

2.2 Event Spaces

“Event Spaces” include all physical and digital environments reasonably associated with the Event, including classrooms, lecture halls, meeting rooms, registration areas, common areas reserved for the Event, hackathon workspaces, official social or networking activities, virtual sessions, Event email lists, collaboration platforms, chat channels, videoconference rooms, repositories, shared documents, issue trackers, judging systems, and other channels designated by the Organizers. Conduct in a public space may also fall within scope when a Participant is representing the Event or Qiskit community, using an official Event account, or engaging another Participant in a manner materially connected to the Event.

2.3 Temporal Scope

The Code applies during the Event and may apply before or after the Event where conduct is materially connected to registration, team formation, Event communications, project collaboration, judging, follow-up activities, or a Participant’s representation of the Event. It is not intended to regulate wholly private conduct unrelated to the Event, except to the extent a governing UConn, IBM, Qiskit, employer, student, or legal process independently applies.

2.4 Defined Terms

- “Organizers” means persons formally designated to administer the Event or this Code, including any on-call Code of Conduct contact.
- “Report” means information submitted in good faith concerning conduct that may violate this Code or another applicable policy.
- “Reporter” means a person who submits or communicates a concern; “Affected Person” means a person alleged to have experienced the conduct; “Respondent” means a person whose conduct is at issue. These Event terms do not alter formal definitions used by UConn or IBM processes.
- “Interim Measure” means a temporary, non-disciplinary step taken to protect safety, preserve Event operations, prevent escalation, or facilitate review, including team separation, channel restrictions, schedule changes, or temporary removal from a space.
- “Event Sanction” means an action imposed under the Organizers’ authority over Event participation, such as a warning, removal from a session, disqualification, or removal from the Event. University or IBM discipline is separate and may be administered only by the appropriate authority.

2.5 Non-Exhaustive Construction

Examples in this Code are illustrative, not exhaustive. The absence of a specific example does not imply that materially similar conduct is permitted. Conversely, a good-faith disagreement, technical error, awkward social interaction, or isolated misunderstanding is not automatically misconduct; context, severity, persistence, impact, intent where relevant, and response after notice may be considered.

2.6 Equal Application and Good-Faith Interpretation

This Code shall be administered without favoritism based on institutional status, technical ability, professional seniority, sponsorship, team placement, or personal relationship. Organizers should distinguish between conduct that is merely unpopular or controversial and conduct that is threatening, harassing, discriminatory, materially disruptive, dishonest, invasive of privacy, unsafe, or otherwise inconsistent with a professional event.

3. Expected Conduct and Professional Participation Standards

3.1 Respectful and Inclusive Participation

Participants are expected to use professional, welcoming, and inclusive language; respect differing viewpoints, cultures, backgrounds, disciplines, and levels of experience; listen without domination or ridicule; accept constructive criticism professionally; recognize others’ contributions; and engage in collaboration before conflict. Participants should be mindful that the Event intentionally welcomes newcomers as well as experienced practitioners.

3.2 Scientific, Technical, and Academic Disagreement

Rigorous disagreement is permitted and encouraged when directed to ideas, methods, evidence, code, models, assumptions, or results rather than to the worth, identity, or dignity of another person. Participants may challenge claims forcefully, identify errors, question methodology, or disagree on social or political implications of technology, provided the manner of engagement does not become a threat, targeted personal attack, discriminatory or sexualized

conduct, repeated harassment, or material disruption. Nothing in this Code is intended to prohibit lawful expression protected by applicable law or University policy.

3.3 Constructive Feedback

Code review, project criticism, judging feedback, and mentoring shall be delivered in a manner reasonably calculated to improve the work or learning experience. Examples of appropriate feedback include identifying a bug, explaining why a circuit or algorithm is inefficient, requesting evidence for a claim, or recommending a different architecture. Humiliation, ridicule, profanity directed at a person, or repeated belittling of a participant's intelligence or experience is not constructive feedback.

3.4 Personal Boundaries and Consent

Participants shall respect reasonable personal boundaries. A person who is asked to stop a nonessential interaction, physical contact, repeated invitation, personal questioning, direct message, photography, or other social approach must do so, absent a legitimate safety, administrative, or professional necessity. Consent must be voluntary and may be withdrawn. Silence, prior social interaction, team membership, professional seniority, or attendance at a networking event does not by itself establish consent to personal or sexual contact.

3.5 Responsible Mentoring, Judging, and Authority

Mentors, judges, speakers, faculty, organizers, sponsors, recruiters, and others with actual or perceived authority shall not use that position to pressure Participants for personal, romantic, sexual, commercial, or unrelated professional favors. They shall avoid implying that access to mentorship, judging outcomes, certificates, referrals, employment opportunities, research opportunities, or Event resources depends on personal compliance unrelated to legitimate Event criteria.

3.6 Professional Networking

Networking is encouraged, including discussion of internships, employment, research, graduate study, and collaboration. Participants may exchange contact information voluntarily. Repeated solicitation after a person declines, pressuring a participant to share a resume or private contact information, misrepresenting an affiliation or employment opportunity, or using Event contact lists for unauthorized mass marketing is prohibited.

3.7 Organizer Directions

Participants shall comply with reasonable instructions concerning room capacity, safety, accessibility, queueing, credentials, time limits, moderation, equipment use, team formation, judging, and venue operations. A Participant may respectfully question or seek clarification of a direction, but may not materially disrupt the Event while a concern is being reviewed.

4. Prohibited Interpersonal Conduct

4.1 Discrimination and Discriminatory Harassment

Discrimination or discriminatory harassment prohibited by applicable UConn policy or law is prohibited at the Event. The Event further adopts the Qiskit community commitment to a harassment-free experience regardless of characteristics identified in the Qiskit Code of Conduct, including age, personal appearance, disability, ethnicity, gender identity or expression, body size, level of experience, nationality, race, religion, caste, or sexual identity or orientation. UConn's current policy additionally protects classifications established by federal and Connecticut law. Nothing in this section narrows the scope of UConn's governing policy.

Event-level action may be appropriate for degrading or exclusionary conduct before it reaches the legal threshold for unlawful harassment. This distinction allows Organizers to maintain professional standards without purporting to make a legal finding.

4.2 Sexualized and Gender-Based Misconduct

Unwelcome sexual attention, sexual advances, requests for sexual favors, sexualized comments directed at a person, sexualized imagery unrelated to a legitimate academic purpose, inappropriate touching, sexual intimidation, sexual exploitation, or other unwelcome conduct of a sexual nature is prohibited. Conduct may be prohibited by this Code regardless of whether it independently meets a statutory or Title IX threshold. Allegations potentially within UConn's discrimination, harassment, sexual misconduct, stalking, or interpersonal-violence policy shall be referred as appropriate.

4.3 Harassment, Bullying, and Targeted Abuse

Public or private harassment, repeated hostile messaging, targeted insults, degrading language, persistent unwanted contact, trolling directed at a participant, humiliation, or conduct reasonably calculated to isolate or intimidate another Participant is prohibited. The assertion that conduct was intended as humor, irony, satire, or “just a joke” does not exempt it from review.

4.4 Threats, Violence, Stalking, and Intimidation

Threatening violence, encouraging violence, physical aggression, stalking, following a person after being asked to stop, blocking a person’s movement, menacing conduct, credible threats to property or systems, or conduct creating an immediate safety risk is prohibited. Participants should not personally intervene in a manner that increases danger; emergencies should be directed to 911 and Event staff as soon as safely practicable.

4.5 Retaliation

Retaliation against a person for making a good-faith report, seeking assistance, declining an unwelcome interaction, serving as a witness, providing information, or participating in a review is prohibited. Retaliation may include threats, intimidation, coercion, exclusion from a team for reporting, adverse networking or judging pressure, interference with witnesses, or online targeting. Good-faith disagreement with an allegation, participation in a fair review, or lawful action taken through an established process is not retaliation merely because it is adverse to another person’s position.

4.6 Complicity and Encouragement

A Participant may violate this Code by knowingly directing, assisting, encouraging, or materially facilitating another person’s serious misconduct. Mere presence, passive association, or failure to confront another person is not by itself complicity, except where a separate reporting duty applies to that individual under law, UConn policy, IBM policy, or an assigned Event role.

5. Privacy, Online Conduct, Communications, Photography, and Media

5.1 Private Information and Doxxing

Participants shall not publish, distribute, expose, or solicit another person’s private information without authorization. This includes home addresses, personal phone numbers, private email addresses, account credentials, private schedules, immigration information, medical information, nonpublic identity information, or other information where the person has a reasonable expectation of privacy. “Doxxing,” outing a private aspect of another person’s identity, or using such information to intimidate or facilitate harassment is prohibited.

5.2 Screenshots, Quotes, and Private Communications

Consistent with the Qiskit Code of Conduct, Participants shall not publish or redistribute screenshots, quotations, or content from private chats, identity-focused community channels, or other communications reasonably understood to be private without appropriate consent. Organizers may preserve relevant communications for safety, moderation, or conduct review. Officially recorded public presentations may be used in accordance with the Event’s separately stated media practices.

5.3 Photography and Recording

Participants shall follow posted Event photography and recording rules and any reasonable request not to photograph or record an individual. No Participant may record private conversations, mentoring sessions, personal disclosures, or restricted technical material in violation of law, policy, posted rules, or an express direction. This Code does not itself constitute a media release; organizer photography, speaker releases, and publication permissions should be handled through separate Event documentation.

5.4 Online and Hybrid Sessions

The same standards apply in virtual rooms, chats, direct messages, collaborative documents, repositories, and other online spaces. Participants shall not engage in abusive chat behavior, repeated disruptive reactions, deliberate audio or screen disruption, unauthorized recording, impersonation, link flooding, malicious file sharing, or attempts to evade a moderator’s restriction through alternate accounts.

5.5 Spam, Unsolicited Promotion, and Automated Content

Repeated unsolicited messages, advertisements, promotional solicitations, mass recruitment messages, or automated content may not be distributed through Event or Qiskit community channels without authorization. Consistent with the Qiskit Code of Conduct, this includes repeated unsolicited output generated by large language models or other automated systems. Reasonable one-to-one networking and properly designated sponsor or career communications remain permitted.

5.6 Identity, Attribution, and Impersonation

Participants shall not impersonate another person, falsely claim to speak for UConn, IBM, Qiskit, a sponsor, an employer, or an Event team, or knowingly falsify credentials, affiliations, awards, or roles. Satire or demonstration content must not be presented in a way reasonably likely to deceive Participants regarding an actual person's identity or institutional authority.

5.7 Social Media

Participants may discuss their own Event experience and publicly presented material, subject to applicable confidentiality, privacy, copyright, media, and professional obligations. Tagging, quoting, or posting images of others should be undertaken with reasonable regard for consent and context. Social media activity materially connected to the Event may be reviewed under this Code when it constitutes harassment, doxxing, threats, retaliation, impersonation, or another covered form of misconduct.

6. Hackathon Integrity, Technical Systems, Data, AI, and Intellectual Property

6.1 Authorized Technical Use

Participants may use computing resources, IBM Quantum services, Qiskit tools, networks, repositories, datasets, APIs, cloud accounts, and Event hardware only as authorized by the applicable account terms, challenge rules, licenses, security requirements, and Event instructions. Access granted for the Event does not confer permission to probe, exploit, disrupt, reverse engineer, exfiltrate, or circumvent systems beyond the scope expressly authorized.

6.2 Credentials and Account Security

Credentials, tokens, API keys, passwords, access links, and other authentication material shall not be shared except where an authorized team account or documented Event procedure expressly permits it. Participants shall not use another person's credentials, attempt to obtain credentials through deception, or defeat access controls, quotas, rate limits, or security mechanisms.

6.3 Security Testing and Vulnerability Discovery

A Participant who inadvertently identifies a suspected vulnerability shall stop activity that could increase risk, preserve relevant non-sensitive details, and report the issue through the appropriate Event, UConn, IBM, or vendor security channel. The Event is not a penetration-testing authorization. Deliberate exploitation, persistence, privilege escalation, data extraction, destructive testing, denial-of-service activity, or testing against third-party systems without explicit authorization is prohibited.

6.4 Malicious Code and Unsafe Artifacts

Participants shall not introduce malware, credential stealers, destructive scripts, cryptominers, unauthorized scanners, harmful payloads, or code intended to compromise another participant's device, account, project, or the Event infrastructure. Proof-of-concept security code may be used only if the challenge expressly authorizes it and the environment and boundaries are clearly defined.

6.5 Project Originality, Attribution, and External Resources

Submissions must comply with published hackathon rules regarding originality, prior work, open-source components, datasets, libraries, templates, and third-party materials. Participants shall not represent another person's work, code, research, results, or ideas as their own. Material contributions by teammates and external sources shall be acknowledged where the rules, license, academic norms, or professional practice require attribution. UConn's academic, scholarly, and professional integrity principles may independently apply to UConn community members and professional events.

6.6 Artificial Intelligence and Automated Assistance

Generative AI, coding assistants, and automated tools may be used only to the extent permitted by the hackathon rules and applicable licenses or platform terms. If AI-assisted work is allowed, teams remain responsible for accuracy, security, licensing, provenance, disclosure requirements, and the final submission. A team may not use AI to fabricate experimental results, citations, team contributions, or evidence of performance, nor to evade a rule requiring human-authored work.

6.7 Data Protection

Participants shall not place confidential, regulated, export-controlled, proprietary, personally identifiable, or otherwise restricted information into public repositories, AI tools, shared notebooks, or third-party services unless authorized. Use only datasets and information that the team has a lawful and permitted basis to use. If sensitive information is discovered inadvertently, stop dissemination and notify an Organizer or the appropriate data owner.

6.8 Team Fairness and Judging Integrity

Team formation, mentorship, judging, and prizes shall be conducted under the published rules. Participants shall not bribe, coerce, threaten, deceive, collude with a judge to obtain an improper advantage, sabotage another team, steal project material, manipulate logs or timestamps, or misrepresent eligibility. Judges and mentors shall disclose material conflicts of interest to the Organizers. Ordinary collaboration across teams is permitted when the challenge rules allow it.

6.9 Intellectual Property

This Code does not assign ownership of participant inventions, code, data, or other works. Ownership, licensing, use of sponsor materials, and publication rights are governed by applicable law, existing institutional obligations, open-source licenses, separate Event terms, and any team agreements. Participants should not assume that public presentation eliminates third-party intellectual-property restrictions or preexisting obligations to an employer, university, sponsor, or collaborator.

7. Venue, Accessibility, Safety, Minors, Property, and Event Operations

7.1 Venue and Physical Safety

Participants shall comply with posted building rules, fire and occupancy limits, emergency instructions, restricted-area designations, and directions from University personnel or authorized venue staff. Blocking exits, tampering with alarms or safety equipment, defeating access controls, unsafe use of electrical equipment, or entering restricted spaces is prohibited. Event organizers should coordinate any unusual setup, high-attendance assembly, open flame, cooking, or other regulated condition with the appropriate University unit.

7.2 Accessibility and Reasonable Accommodation

The Event shall be administered consistently with applicable UConn accessibility requirements. Participants shall not interfere with another person's approved accommodation, assistive technology, service animal, interpreter, captioning, accessible seating, or other accessibility measure. Requests for accommodation should be directed to the designated Event contact and routed through applicable University procedures. UConn requires event-specific publications to include its current accessibility statement and nondiscrimination notice.

7.3 Religious and Personal Needs

Organizers should make reasonable efforts, consistent with applicable University policy, to support approved religious accommodations and other legally required accommodations. Participants shall not mock, obstruct, or retaliate against another person for requesting or using an accommodation.

7.4 Minors

If any person under eighteen participates, the Event shall follow the UConn Protection of Minors and Reporting of Child Abuse and Neglect Policy to the extent applicable. Event staff must not assume that a general Code of Conduct substitutes for required registration, supervision, training, background screening, or reporting obligations. UConn policy identifies specific requirements for University-sponsored activities involving minors and provides that most UConn employees, other than student employees, are mandated reporters under Connecticut law.

7.5 Medical and Emergency Situations

For an immediate threat to life or safety, call 911. Participants should promptly follow emergency notifications, evacuation directions, shelter instructions, and requests from emergency personnel. Event staff should not promise medical confidentiality beyond their role or attempt to substitute Event processes for emergency or professional care. A medical event, disability, or request for assistance shall not be treated as misconduct merely because it disrupts normal scheduling.

7.6 Property and Personal Belongings

Theft, intentional damage, unauthorized removal, misuse, or concealment of another person's property, Event equipment, University property, sponsor equipment, or team materials is prohibited. Participants are responsible for safeguarding their own devices and credentials. Found property should be given to an Organizer or appropriate University office rather than accessed or searched for identifying information beyond what is reasonably necessary to return it.

7.7 Alcohol, Smoking, Controlled Substances, and Weapons

Participants shall comply with all applicable law and UConn policies regarding alcohol, smoking and vaping, controlled substances, weapons, and campus safety. This Code does not create permission to possess or use any item otherwise restricted by University policy or law. No Event representative may imply that hackathon participation, sponsorship, or social programming waives those rules. Alcohol, if ever served at a University-sponsored event, is subject to UConn's specific authorization and service requirements; absent an expressly authorized Event function, participants should assume alcohol is not part of the Event.

7.8 Attendance Credentials and Access

Badges, invitations, check-in records, restricted links, and room access may be used to manage capacity and safety. Participants shall not transfer restricted credentials or facilitate unauthorized entry. Saturday's hackathon is an in-person activity at UConn Storrs; any person registered for that component must be able to attend on campus and comply with on-site requirements.

8. Reporting, Confidentiality, Evidence, and Immediate Response

8.1 Immediate Danger

For emergencies or conduct presenting an immediate threat to physical safety, contact 911. UConn Police identifies 860-486-4800 for non-emergency police matters at Storrs. A Participant should prioritize personal safety and is not required to confront a person whose conduct appears unsafe.

8.2 Event Reporting Channels

The Event will maintain designated Code of Conduct contacts with sufficient authority and independence to respond during Event activities. Reports may be made in person to a designated Event Organizer or through the reporting method identified in official Event communications. Consistent with the official Qiskit Code of Conduct, Participants may also use Qiskit's Code of Conduct reporting mechanism for matters within Qiskit community scope. Matters requiring an immediate Event response should be brought promptly to an Event Organizer when practicable.

8.3 UConn Reporting Resources

Concerns involving discrimination, discriminatory harassment, sexual or gender-based harassment, sexual misconduct, stalking, retaliation, or related conduct may fall within UConn's Policy Against Discrimination, Harassment, and Related Interpersonal Violence and should be referred to the Office for Inclusion and Civil Rights as appropriate. Current UConn contact information includes equity@uconn.edu and 860-486-2943 for Storrs and regional campuses. Student conduct matters may also fall within the Office of Community Standards process.

8.4 What a Report Should Include

A report should include, to the extent known and safe to provide, the date and approximate time, location or digital channel, persons involved, description of the conduct, witnesses, relevant links or files, whether the conduct is continuing, and any immediate safety or accessibility needs. A Reporter need not conduct an investigation or obtain proof before seeking assistance.

8.5 Preservation of Evidence

Participants should preserve relevant messages, links, timestamps, screenshots, files, or other records without unlawfully accessing another person's account or broadly redistributing private content. Organizers should limit collection to information reasonably necessary for triage, response, referral, and documentation, and should handle records in accordance with applicable University or IBM requirements.

8.6 Privacy and Limits on Confidentiality

Reports will be handled as privately as reasonably practicable, with information shared on a need-to-know basis for safety, review, referral, or compliance. Organizers shall not promise absolute confidentiality. UConn employees and IBM personnel may have independent reporting obligations; University records may also be subject to applicable legal and institutional requirements. A Reporter should be informed, when practicable, before information is escalated outside the Event team unless immediate safety, law, or policy requires prompt action.

8.7 Anonymous and Third-Party Reports

Anonymous and witness reports may be considered. The ability to investigate or take individualized action may be limited where essential facts cannot be verified, but an anonymous report may still support safety planning, pattern recognition, moderation, or referral. Organizers shall not require an Affected Person to personally confront a Respondent as a condition of receiving assistance.

8.8 Good-Faith Reporting and False Information

A report is not improper merely because an allegation is not substantiated. Knowingly fabricating material facts, falsifying evidence, or intentionally making a report for the purpose of harassment may itself violate this Code. Good-faith mistakes, incomplete recollections, or differing interpretations do not constitute a false report without evidence of knowing fabrication or bad faith.

8.9 IBM Employee Duty

The official Qiskit Code of Conduct states that an IBM employee who witnesses a Qiskit Code of Conduct violation is responsible for filing a Code of Conduct violation report. Nothing in this Event Code alters IBM's internal reporting, HR, Business Conduct Guidelines, or business-partner procedures.

9. Review, Interim Measures, Enforcement, Sanctions, and Referrals

9.1 Event-Level Triage

Upon receiving a concern, the designated Organizer should first assess immediate safety, ongoing disruption, accessibility needs, preservation of evidence, potential conflicts of interest, and whether the matter should be referred promptly to UConn, IBM/Qiskit, law enforcement, emergency services, or another authority. Event-level review is administrative and protective; it is not a substitute for a University disciplinary process, criminal investigation, or civil adjudication.

9.2 Interim Measures

Where reasonably necessary, Organizers may impose temporary measures before reaching a final Event decision. Such measures may include separating Participants or teams, changing seating or schedules, assigning a different mentor, restricting direct messages or channel access, removing a Participant from a particular session, preserving access logs, or temporarily suspending Event participation. Interim measures should be tailored to the identified risk and should not be characterized as a final finding when no final finding has been made.

9.3 Fair and Impartial Review

When circumstances permit, a Respondent should be informed of the substance of the concern and given a reasonable opportunity to provide relevant information before a non-emergency Event sanction is imposed. The review may be abbreviated where immediate action is required for safety or Event continuity. A person with a material personal, supervisory, competitive, or financial conflict should not serve as the sole decision-maker if a reasonably available alternative exists.

9.4 Decision Standard for Event Measures

For Event-participation decisions, Organizers may act on a reasonable, good-faith assessment of the available information and the Event's safety and operational needs. This Code does not establish the evidentiary standard for

UConn or IBM proceedings; those entities apply their own governing standards and procedures. Event Organizers should avoid announcing legal conclusions or findings under policies they are not authorized to adjudicate.

9.5 Available Event Actions

Depending on severity, persistence, risk, prior notice, and the authority available to the Organizers, actions may include: informal redirection; a private warning; a written warning; a request to stop or remove content; moderation or deletion within an Event-controlled channel; change of team or mentor; restriction from a particular activity or resource; disqualification from judging or prizes where the hackathon rules permit; removal from one or more Event spaces; removal from the remainder of the Event; denial of re-entry; referral to UConn; referral to IBM/Qiskit; referral to a participant's home institution or employer where appropriate and lawful; or contact with law enforcement or emergency services. IBM retains separate authority under the Qiskit Code of Conduct over Qiskit community spaces and participation.

9.6 Proportionality

Event responses should be reasonably proportionate to the conduct and the need to protect Participants and Event integrity. Factors may include severity, whether conduct was intentional or repeated, whether a boundary or warning was ignored, impact on the Affected Person or Event, risk of recurrence, abuse of authority, attempts to conceal or retaliate, and willingness to correct lower-level conduct. Serious threats, violence, sexual misconduct, doxxing, deliberate system compromise, or comparable high-risk conduct may justify immediate removal without prior warning.

9.7 No Guaranteed Progressive Discipline

The Event is not required to use sanctions in escalating order. A warning appropriate for a minor first-time disruption may be inadequate for serious misconduct. Conversely, removal is not required for every technical or social mistake. Organizers should document significant decisions and the basis for them.

9.8 Limited Reconsideration

Where a sanction is not an emergency removal and time permits, a Participant may request prompt reconsideration by a different designated Organizer on the basis of material factual error, conflict of interest, or materially new information. This optional Event-level review does not replace or limit any appeal, grievance, conduct, or reporting process available under UConn, IBM, or law.

9.9 Cooperation and Non-Interference

Participants shall not destroy relevant evidence, pressure witnesses, evade a restriction through alternate accounts or credentials, or knowingly obstruct an authorized Event response. A Participant is not required to waive legal rights or provide information to an Event Organizer beyond what governing rules require; however, refusal to comply with reasonable access or safety directions may affect continued Event participation.

10. Illustrative Applications and Authority Notes

The following examples illustrate how this Code is intended to operate. They are non-exhaustive and do not predetermine the outcome of any actual report.

Scenario	Example	Application
Technical disagreement	A participant says a proposed algorithm is incorrect and explains why, even forcefully.	Permitted when directed to the work rather than the person; professional criticism is not harassment merely because it is uncomfortable.
Belittling a newcomer	A mentor repeatedly calls a beginner “clueless” and mocks basic questions after being asked to stop.	Potential violation; targeted degrading conduct and abuse of a mentoring role may warrant removal from mentoring duties or further action.
Unwelcome messaging	After a participant declines a social invitation, another continues sending personal messages throughout the Event.	Potential violation; stop when a reasonable boundary is communicated.
Sexualized joke	A participant directs a sexual joke at a teammate and says it was “only ironic.”	Potential violation; ironic or joking presentation does not excuse unwelcome sexualized conduct.

Scenario	Example	Application
Photography	A participant photographs a public speaker where Event rules allow it.	Generally permitted, subject to posted rules and speaker restrictions. Photographing a participant who has asked not to be photographed may violate this Code.
Private screenshot	A participant posts screenshots from a private team or identity-focused channel to social media without consent.	Potential violation; privacy and Qiskit screenshot/quotation restrictions may apply.
Resume networking	An industry attendee asks whether a participant wishes to share a resume and accepts “no” immediately.	Permitted. Repeated pressure, deceptive recruiting, or use of registration data for mass solicitation may violate this Code.
AI coding assistant	A team uses an AI assistant where the hackathon rules permit it and discloses use if required.	Permitted, subject to rules, licensing, privacy, security, and accuracy responsibilities.
Fabricated benchmark	A team invents quantum hardware results or edits logs to appear faster.	Prohibited; misrepresentation undermines competition and scholarly integrity.
API key sharing	A participant posts a personal IBM Quantum token in a public team channel.	Unsafe and generally prohibited; revoke or rotate the credential and notify the appropriate support contact.
Vulnerability discovery	A participant notices an apparent security flaw while using an authorized service.	Stop escalating the test and report through the appropriate channel; the Event is not blanket authorization for penetration testing.
Team sabotage	A participant intentionally deletes another team’s repository or corrupts its data.	Prohibited; may also require security or law-enforcement referral.
Heated political discussion	Participants disagree strongly about public policy implications of quantum technology.	Not prohibited solely because the discussion is political or controversial; personal attacks, threats, discriminatory harassment, or material disruption remain prohibited.
Anonymous report	A witness submits a concern without identifying themselves.	May be reviewed; available action depends on the information that can be responsibly verified.
Emergency threat	A person makes a credible threat of immediate violence.	Prioritize safety; call 911 and notify Event personnel. Immediate removal or emergency measures may occur without prior warning.
Minor participant	A 17-year-old registers for an Event component.	Organizers must determine and satisfy applicable UConn minor-protection requirements; the Code alone is not sufficient.
Accessibility	A participant blocks reserved accessible seating after being asked to move.	Potential violation and operational issue; comply with accessibility arrangements and organizer directions.
Retaliation	A judge threatens to lower a team’s score because a member reported the judge’s conduct.	Prohibited; report immediately and remove the conflicted judge from the matter pending review.

10.1 Event Reporting and Support

Participants may report concerns to a designated Event Organizer or through the reporting method identified in official Event communications. Immediate threats to life or safety should be directed to 911 or appropriate emergency personnel. Accessibility or accommodation matters should be directed to the Event accessibility contact or the appropriate University office. Participants should not delay emergency assistance while attempting to make an Event-level report.

10.2 Principal Authorities Consulted

Official Qiskit Code of Conduct: <https://quantum.cloud.ibm.com/docs/en/guides/code-of-conduct>

UConn Policy Against Discrimination, Harassment, and Related Interpersonal Violence: <https://policy.uconn.edu/2015/12/29/policy-against-discrimination-harassment-and-related-interpersonal-violence/>

UConn Acceptable Use, Information Technology: <https://policy.uconn.edu/2012/06/21/acceptable-use-information-technology/>

UConn Protection of Minors and Reporting of Child Abuse and Neglect: <https://policy.uconn.edu/2016/03/29/protection-of-minors-and-reporting-of-child-abuse-and-neglect-policy/>

UConn Non-Discrimination and Event Accessibility Statements: <https://policy.uconn.edu/2011/05/31/non-discrimination-policy-statements/>

UConn Academic, Scholarly, and Professional Integrity and Misconduct: <https://policy.uconn.edu/category/academic-and-student-life/>

UConn Student Code: <https://community.uconn.edu/the-student-code/>